resources in the wider region, rebuild Afghanistan, reboot the relationship with Russia, and combat terrorism. In all these areas, however, China obviously plays a prominent role.

At the moment, the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation is fully aligned with China's vision. However, the SCO is mainly an organisation for soft security issues and not for hard security issues. Hence, unless China through the SCO legal framework and the "Shanghai Spirit" – the set of values that underpins the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation – is able to shape and conform India's position on issues of vital importance to China, like the South China Sea dispute, India's entry into the SCO is not in any way a signal of it succumbing to Chinese pressure and a more China-led order in the region.

India will in the context of the SCO stand up for its interests and values, but the SCO is also a venue for India to collaborate with China on a number of issues. The SCO might even provide impetus for the Indian military to interact with the PLA and shed misgivings about each other. Constant vigilance is certainly required, but overall, transactions with China need to be adequately de-securitised. India also needs to ensure that its policies towards China are steered less by the intelligence community and more by those with comprehensive knowledge of dealing constructively with China. In a way, for India, navigating regional diplomacy in the SCO would prove to be far more complex and challenging than in any multilateral forum so far.

In the absence of a direct land border with Central Asia, India realises that any attempt at matching the Russian or Chinese leverage in Eurasia would be unrealistic. The Indian intention to join the Eurasian Great Game is a good one, but India needs to improve its diplomatic capability, scholarship, and depth of understanding of Eurasia and China to play that game.